Months later, members of another disenfranchised group would hold their own protest against police brutality—but this time in Tel Aviv, normally an oasis of calm. They shut the Ayalon, the main urban freeway, at the height of the afternoon rush. Toward sunset they moved to city hall, where some protesters threw stones and bottles at the police, who fired tear gas and stun grenades in response. Dozens of people were hurt.

The proximate cause for all of this was a two-minute video that showed a uniformed Israeli soldier, Damas Pakada, standing with his bicycle on a street in Holon, a southern suburb of Tel Aviv. A police officer approached and, seemingly without any provocation, began shoving and punching Pakada. Several others joined the fray and detained Pakada for alleged assault.

Pakada had arrived from Ethiopia seven years earlier, one of about 130,000 Ethiopian Jews who live here, accounting for slightly less than 2 per cent of the population. While there are no hard statistics, the community has long complained of brutal and unfair treatment at the hands of police; a local activist group says that nearly one-third of the minors in Israeli prisons are of Ethiopian descent. “There’s been police violence against the Ethiopian community for many years, but it’s been very, very difficult to prove,” said Fentahun Assefa-Dawit, the director of Tebeka, an NGO that advocates on behalf of Ethiopian Israelis. “What’s different this time is the footage.”

Most of the Ethiopian Jews arrived in two major waves of immigration in the 1980s and early 1990s, during the long civil war in their native country. The government forbade Jews from emigrating, so the Israeli army and intelligence services smuggled them out on a series of clandestine flights. The journey was a culture shock—from rural poverty to a modern country. The immigrants were initially housed in trailer homes, and faced a humiliating ritual upon arrival. When the first big wave arrived in the mid-1980s, the chief rabbis required them to undergo a symbolic *mikvah*, a ritual immersion required for converts. They were the only Jews forced to do so, and hundreds of them marched on the airport in protest, threatening to leave the country. The rabbinate eventually relented.

“Every white person who wants to immigrate is welcome. Every Ethiopian person, regardless of how they practiced Judaism, has been